

Source: Montville, Joseph V. (ed). 1990.
Conflict and peacemaking in multiethnic
societies. Lexington, MA: Lexington Books.

1

The Nation-State Fallacy

Uri Ra'anan

Toward a New Typology: Semantic Barriers

It has been one of the fallacies of contemporary political thought, particularly in the West, to assume that the international arena of the twentieth century is occupied largely, if not almost exclusively, by nation-states or nation-states-to-be. (The term *nation-state* is either tautological or, if it is to be lucid and coherent, presumably would have to refer to a polity whose territorial and juridical frontiers coincide with the ethnic boundaries of the national entity with which that state is identified, frequently by its very name.)^a To be sure, protagonists of the nation-state view will usually admit that one portion of the globe—the so-called developing areas—does not quite fit their conceptual framework. However, they will quickly add that in these areas, a process is under way, subsumed under the facile heading “nation building,” that will result almost inevitably in the area’s “normalization”—its *Gleichschaltung* with the rest of the world.

Those who hold this view will dismiss as tribalism any rejoinders pointing out that these areas already comprise many genuine national entities—such as the Yoruba, Ibo, Ewe, and others—frequently numbering millions of members and possessing a well-developed culture, language, and historical consciousness, but that the arbitrary boundaries of the postcolonial states usually cut across or ignore these ethnic units. Consequently, the attempt to “build nations” on the basis of the current artificial frontiers and states actually may undermine or destroy existing nationalities. Most of the advocates of the prevailing trend in political thought will regard such arguments, at best, as anachronistic and likely to hamper their streamlined models of modernization and the economic and functional efficiency to be implemented by highly centralized states and their bureaucracies.

Adapted from Uri Ra'anan, “Ethnic Conflict: Toward a New Typology,” in Uri Ra'anan, ed., *Ethnic Resurgence in Modern Democratic States: A Multidisciplinary Approach to Human Resources and Conflict* (New York: Pergamon Press, 1980). Reprinted with permission.

The better informed of these analysts perhaps will allow that, in addition to not applying to the developing areas, their theory also does not provide an entirely appropriate description of conditions within the successor states of the three former great polyglot dynastic entities of Southeastern, Eastern, and Central Europe—the Ottoman, Romanov, and Hapsburg empires. Generally, however, they will downplay these anomalies by categorizing the current nationality conflicts of that part of the world as mere minority problems.

The rest of the globe (approximately the region known as the West) is viewed predominantly in contemporary thought as the very birthplace of the modern nation-state and its primary showcase.

The Nation-State: A Negligible Minority

On the political map of the world, the territorial frontiers of the state and the ethnic boundaries of the constituent nation rarely coincide. Iceland, metropolitan Portugal, Norway, and a few others are the exceptions among the approximately 170 more-or-less sovereign countries existing today. In very many cases, the state is larger than the "nation"; that is, the juridical limits of the state extend well beyond the area settled by its *Staatsvolk* (that is, the ethnic group that created the state, is largely identified with it, constitutes the bulk of its elite, and is the source of the predominant culture). For instance, Great Russians make up only half the population of the U.S.S.R., and even if, by a very wide stretch of the political imagination, one were to accept as "co-*Staatsvolker*" of the U.S.S.R. the fourteen other national groups for which the various constituent Soviet republics were named, the boundaries of the Soviet Union would still embrace some 26 million additional citizens (almost one-tenth of the population) who belong to "other" or "minority" ethnic entities and occupy considerable portions of the country. Similarly, in the Yugoslav case, the original *Staatsvolk*, the Serbs, make up little more than 40 percent of the inhabitants. Even if Croats, Slovenes, Macedonians, and Montenegrins, whose names the other Yugoslav republics bear, were to be regarded in the same light as the Serbs, this would still leave Yugoslavia with other or minority nationalities amounting to nearly one-fifth of its total citizenry and inhabiting sizable stretches of its territory.^b

Nor is the West exempt from such situations. France, the classical nation-state of the political textbooks, contains, adjacent to its outer limits, German-speaking Alsatians; Italian-speaking inhabitants of the eastern Riviera and Corsica; Catalans and Basques at either end of the Pyrenees; Celtic Bretons; and Flemings southwest of the Belgian frontier—amounting altogether to nearly one-tenth of metropolitan France's citizens, without even counting the population of French "overseas departments" or the large number of foreign laborers in the country, North Africans and others. In the Canadian case, even if one regarded as *Staatsvolker* the descendants of settlers both from the

British Isles and from France (Quebecois and Acadians), each in their respective sections of the country, one would still be left with a "third Canada"—including Scandinavians, Germans, Dutch, Ukrainians, Poles, Jews, Italians, Indians, and Eskimos—exceeding one-fourth of Canada's citizens and inhabiting considerable stretches of its territory, especially in the prairies, the north, and the northwest.

In the Far East, even the island state of Japan, despite its long history of relative isolation, is far from homogeneous. It includes not only a sizable Korean minority but also the aboriginal Ainu, who persist tenaciously in the country's northernmost reaches.

If in these and at least 100 other instances the state is larger in size than the area inhabited by the nation or *Staatsvolk*, there are, conversely, quite a few cases in which the boundaries of the nation exceed the territorial limits of any one state. There is a German nation, but there are several German states (the German Federal Republic, the German Democratic Republic, possibly West Berlin—if it can be regarded as a separate state—and perhaps even Austria). Switzerland, Liechtenstein, and Luxembourg, although a majority of their inhabitants speak German and/or German dialects, presumably would not be considered German states by most analysts. A Korean and a Vietnamese nation exist, but each has been divided into two separate, more-or-less sovereign states (one of which, South Vietnam, subsequently was eliminated by conquest). Quite a few observers, within and outside the Middle East, argue that in spite of some historical, ethnic, linguistic (dialectal), and religious differences, the various Arab groups constitute one single nation, whereas currently there are twenty-one Arab states. There is a Jewish state, but it contains less than one-fourth of the Jewish people, as well as a sizable Arab minority.

There is a Hungarian state, but the frontiers imposed upon it by the post-World War I and II settlements exclude nearly 3 million Magyars from the motherland (in Transylvania, southern Slovakia, and the Vojvodina), not to speak of the many hundreds of thousands in the New World who are of Magyar descent. There are two Chinese states (actually there are three, if one regards Singapore from the ethnic point of view), but they do not include either the Chinese inhabitants of Hong Kong or the millions of "overseas Chinese" in Southeast Asia and in the Western Hemisphere. Even in relatively homogeneous Scandinavia, the Swedish state fails to include half a million Swedes in neighboring Finland, right across the Gulf of Bothnia, not to mention the millions of ethnic Swedes in North America. These are but a few of the scores of examples in which the ethnic limits of the nation transcend the territorial frontiers of one particular state.

Thus, in well over 90 percent of the independent countries existing today, the state either is considerably larger or much smaller than the area inhabited by the corresponding nation or *Staatsvolk*. Nation-states, far from constitut-

ing the rule on the contemporary political map, remain a very exceptional phenomenon—if a high degree of ethnic homogeneity and congruity between the geographic outlines of the state and nation are regarded as the primary criteria of the nation-state. (If these are not the criteria, then little, if any, real meaning attaches to the term.)

If this is true today, how much more was it the case during earlier decades and centuries? After all, only in the second, third, and fourth quarters of this century has it become customary to attempt to “clean up” the ethnic map. This has included genocidal measures: against Jews and Gypsies under Hitler; Crimean Tatars, Volga Germans, and Chechen-Ingush under Stalin; Ibos in Nigeria; southern blacks in the Sudan; both Tutsi and Hutu in Rwanda and Burundi; Armenians in Anatolia; overseas Chinese in certain parts of Southeast Asia; and Kurds in Iraq. Peoples have been expelled: Asians from Uganda and Germans from most of East-Central Europe. Populations have been exchanged through agreement, by semivoluntary moves, as a result of fear, or in the wake of unilateral measures: Hellenes from Turkey and Turks from Greece; Macedonian Bulgars from Greece and Hellenes from Bulgaria; Turks from Bulgaria and Bulgars from European Turkey—all in the 1920s; most Hindus and Sikhs from Pakistan and many Muslims from India; practically all Jews from the Arab countries and about three-fourths of the Arabs from the area that became Israel in 1948–49; and some of the few Ukrainians and Belorussians still remaining in truncated post-World War I Poland and many ethnic Poles from former Polish territories annexed to the U.S.S.R.

Despite all these ethnic clean-up measures, genuine nation-states have remained the exception on the political landscape, as has been noted. Obviously, there were even fewer instances of ethnic homogeneity in the period that preceded these measures—that is, up to 1920—not to mention the fact that until the two Balkan wars and World War I, there were three great multinational states: the Ottoman, Hapsburg, and Romanov empires (only the last of these was succeeded by an equally polyglot state—the U.S.S.R.). Moreover, during the first half of the nineteenth century, there were thirty-nine separate German and nine Italian states. Nation-states, therefore, not only are very much in the minority on the contemporary political scene but have been even more exceptional in history.

Multiethnic States and Nationalism

Thus, multiethnic polities have constituted the norm across the ages and still do today. Despite this prevalence of polyglot entities—or perhaps because of it—*nationalism* (that is, the self-assertion of ethnic groups, ranging from primary cultural, religious, and educational endeavors, via political organization, to the ultimate step of struggling for territorial or state power) has been a highly significant phenomenon throughout most of recorded history. Many contemporary Western political scientists deny this and trace “true” national-

ism, which they regard as a “modern ideology,” no further back than the French Revolution or, at most, the absolutist centralized states of the seventeenth century. Of course, anyone acquainted with the paeans to England and the English in Shakespeare and to the concept of Italy in Dante—not to speak of the lyrical and epic portrayals of the struggles for cultural and religious self-expression and national survival of the Hellenes and the Hebrews in the Greek classics and in the Bible—will wonder if this view is not somewhat simplistic.

It is not difficult to grasp the reason for the apparent paradox that multiethnic states, rather than posing an obstacle, constitute a breeding ground for the growth of nationalistic manifestations. An awareness of national differences and a perception of the incompatibility of interests are far less likely to develop in ethnically homogeneous societies, where individuals usually do not encounter in their daily lives problems caused by the need to function (during study, work, or litigation) in a language other than their mother tongue, to adjust to unaccustomed and incomprehensible cultural traditions, or to compete economically and socially with personalities molded by an entirely different background and heritage. Conversely, the sudden impact of one ethnic group on another—whether because of invasion, annexation, migration, or simple fluctuation in the language or cultural frontiers between two peoples—cannot but give rise to some, most, or all of these problems, which are likely to be aggravated if the nationalities concerned find themselves within the frontiers of a single state. In that case, they are likely to seek satisfaction of their aspirations through a struggle for political control of the whole country or, at least, portions of it.

Thus, it is symptomatic that the center of French separatism in Canada is to be found not in the solidly French Quebec hinterland but in multinational Montreal. Similarly, the focus of the Belgian nationality conflict is bilingual Brussels, not the homogeneously Flemish farmland of the north or the overwhelmingly Walloon coal areas of the south.

One can, of course, discover instances in which distinctly nationalistic tendencies have become evident even in apparently homogeneous countries, but closer investigation usually will reveal that in these cases, extraneous ethnic elements actually have impinged on the native population. For example, Iceland, an almost “pure” nation-state, recently has shown signs of somewhat strident nationalism. In fact, this new nationalism is largely due to the situation on the sea surrounding the island, where a large proportion of this nation of fishermen spends its working days and has to compete with trawlers from Britain and other countries. In a sense, therefore, Iceland is ethnically homogeneous only on land, not on the equally important adjacent waters.

Pathetic Fallacies

Perhaps the argument presented so far should not be regarded as particularly revolutionary, as it is based on data with which at least historians of the

period 1806 to 1939 have long been acquainted. However, for some reason, quite a few adherents of other disciplines, particularly Western economists and some political scientists, recently seem to have discovered—with surprise and sometimes with shock—that even contemporary Western societies contain mutually competing, often antagonistic, culturally, religiously, and/or linguistically distinct ethnic groups that regard themselves as nationalities or even as nations-to-be and struggle for political and/or territorial power.

It may be useful to review the origins and antecedents of the still-fashionable misapprehensions of such analysts and observers. One of the pathetic fallacies of the period that began in the closing stages of World War II was to assume that the great wave of nationalism, which had swept across Europe between the Napoleonic and Hitlerian eras, had fulfilled its aspirations through the creation of a series of supposed nation-states and would somehow ebb away. The futuristic literature of the period was full of patent panaceas, such as the common expectation that federalism would dominate the post-World War II world and fuse the remnants of nationalism into some higher, supranational amalgam, embodied in various large federations of states.

It was taken for granted, moreover, that national fervor had begun to fade away in an easterly direction. After all—so most economic and political planners of the time argued—the concept of the modern nation-state was born during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries in the bureaucratically centralized, postmedieval societies of Western Europe: Britain, France, and the Netherlands. By the nineteenth century, so they claimed, following the French revolutionary elaboration of the idea of *la nation* and in reaction to the Napoleonic expansionist drive for conquest, nationalism had reached Central Europe, leading eventually to the formation of unitary states in Germany and Italy, and then had moved eastward to the Balkans and East-Central and Eastern Europe, which became known, par excellence, as the hotbeds of national strife. By the twentieth century, the wave was said to have moved still further east to the so-called Middle East, eventually reaching the rest of colonial Asia and Africa.

By this time, the West (that is, Western Europe and the Western Hemisphere), where so-called nation-states had been established centuries ago, was supposed to have recovered from, or even to have proved immune to, the “infantile malady” that was now ravaging less-fortunate lands. This was believed so firmly that Western states such as Switzerland, France, and the United States were held as the classical examples of societies that had solved the “national problem.”

Events in recent years, of course, have demonstrated that these obituary notices for Western nationalism were, to put it mildly, premature. Belgium has become the arena of revived Flemish and Walloon separatism, and the end is not in sight. France has been confronted by national movements of the Bret-

ons, the Corsicans, and the Basques, and Spain by movements of the Basques and Catalans. The growth of French separatism in Quebec appeared meteoric until recently. The United States has come to acknowledge that it is striving for a pluralistic society rather than a melting pot. Then there is, of course, Ulster, not to mention the rise of Welsh and Scottish nationalism in the United Kingdom. Finally, in the classical home of supposed national resolution, Switzerland, a very sharp conflict has exacerbated relations between the German Protestant majority of the canton of Berne and the predominantly Catholic and overwhelmingly French population of the Jura, in the north of the canton. The secession of the northernmost portion of the Jura from Berne has not resolved the problem.

Why have the prophets of the 1940s and 1950s turned out to be so mistaken? The reasons, apparently, include academic prejudice and wishful thinking. As has been pointed out, many of the would-be prophets have been economists or adherents of certain categories of political science, especially those with a functionalistic bias. Professionally, they have tended to be enamored of sheer size, “efficiency,” and “viability.” To most of them, it has appeared axiomatic that large territorial units, with rich, variegated resources, would prove to be more competent and effective members of the global community than their smaller, poorer counterparts. Consequently, these prophets have been prejudiced in favor of sizable federations and other large polities and have tried to convince themselves and others that existing states (however arbitrarily their frontiers might mutilate ethnic units) are, in fact, nation-states or nation-states-to-be.

In contrast, most historians and anthropologists have been inclined to doubt whether, even under modern (that is, postmedieval) conditions, artificial nation building really has been successful to any degree, except perhaps temporarily in a couple of West European instances and in some immigrant societies. Moreover, historians have been well aware that the sultans in five centuries were unable to build an Ottoman nation out of Turks, Arabs, Armenians, Kurds, and Greeks; the tsars in several centuries could not build a single nation out of Great Russians, Ukrainians, Belorussians, Poles, Finns, and Georgians; nor could the Hapsburg emperor-kings, in a similar time span, build one nation out of Germans, Hungarians, Czechs, and Croats. There is no indication that these large, polyglot but ramshackle empires, beset by unending struggles for self-government of the subject nationalities, really were more efficient, stable, or happy societies than those of their much smaller successor states that were reasonably homogeneous ethnically, such as Estonia and Lithuania (states that were destroyed subsequently not by internal conflict but by Soviet imperialism).

Admittedly, for a brief period after World War II, it appeared as if the advocates of mass, size, and federation might have a point. The European Economic Community (EEC) was founded; unions between Mali and Senegal

and between Egypt and Syria (the United Arab Republic) were established. However, the latter two unions quickly broke up, and although the EEC has grown in size and economic stature, Europe's political reality remains de Gaulle's "l'Europe des patries," rather than a true European federation whose members really have merged their individual sovereignties and foreign policies.

Moreover, centrifugal tendencies quickly became apparent and spread within existing states between Slovaks and Czechs; Croats, Macedonians, and Serbs; Ukrainians, Georgians, Lithuanians, Jews, and Great Russians; Walloons and Flemings; Basques and Castilians; Francophones and Anglophones in Canada; Kurds and Arabs in Iraq; black Africans and Arabs in the Sudan; Ibos, Yorubas, and Hausa-Fulanis in Nigeria; and Bengalis and Biharis in East Pakistan (Bangladesh). Thus, if anything, the trend has been toward the breakdown of existing polities into still-smaller entities rather than their merger into larger units.

The survival of so-called regional organizations in Africa, the Arab world, and Latin America in no way contradicts this trend, as these structures remain mere sounding boards and are not evolving as supersovereignties. This is quite evident from the continued hostility between Ethiopia and Somalia within the Organization of African Unity and between Syria and Iraq and Algeria and Morocco within the Arab League.

Three Concepts of Nationality

Conceivably, current misapprehensions might not have persisted but for the well-nigh impenetrable semantic confusion, especially in the West, that has enveloped the whole topic of nationality and nationalism because of a failure to recognize that there are at least three distinct meanings, with entirely different connotations, in various regions of the world.

The Western View

In the West (that is, roughly, Europe west of the Rhine and the Western Hemisphere), a primarily territorial concept of nationality (having much in common with the legal concept of *jus soli*) has developed during the modern era. Western Europe was one area where classical feudalism really flourished. Historical myth notwithstanding, feudalism of this type did not necessarily breed anarchy but rather provided, in several cases, a congenial environment for the growth of centralization and bureaucratic statehood, as evidenced by the history of the early Norman-Angevin monarchy, from William I to Henry II, and that of Norman Sicily.

On the basis of this heritage, the postmedieval, absolutist Western

European monarchies of the Tudors and the Valois were able to establish modern, bureaucratic, centralized states. In these instances—and perhaps in these instances alone—some degree of nation building can be demonstrated to have occurred. In a sense, it was these new *states* that assisted the process of creating the modern French and English *nations*, rather than the other way around (although, as has already been pointed out, even in these cases, this process, extended over generations, has not been completed to this very day).

Therefore, allegiance to the state, residence therein, and submission to its jurisdiction are the hallmarks of the Western idea of nationality—to the point where, in American English, one speaks of a *national* of a country when one actually means a *citizen*. The two terms have become synonymous. It is an individual's place of residence and his passport that largely determine his nationality in the West; that is, the criteria are primarily territorial and juridical, precisely as in the case of *jus soli*. For the same reasons, the concepts of state and nation have tended to converge in the English language, to a degree that causes many to refer to *national interests* when, in fact, they mean *state interests*, while others speak simplistically of a world of nation-states.

As already demonstrated, however, there are rather few instances in which the limits of the state and those of its constituent nation really coincide. Loyalty and commitment to the state and to the nation often not only are not synonymous, but may be mutually incompatible. In order to unite a nation split asunder by official boundaries or to win independence for a nationality that lacks sovereign territory, individuals sometimes feel impelled to fight the states in which they dwell and whose formal citizenship they hold. In the pre-1938 Austrian Republic, being a nationalist meant supporting an *Anschluss* between Austria and the German Reich—that is, attempting to obliterate the republic and submerge it in a greater Germany. Thus, *nationalist* and Austrian *patriot* were antithetical terms. The interests of the state and the nation simply were incompatible. The same was true, of course, of any of the particularist German and Italian states in the first half of the nineteenth century.

Similarly, being a Jordanian or Lebanese patriot and being a pan-Arab nationalist who happens to be a citizen of Jordan or Lebanon are antithetical concepts. The creation of a pan-Arab empire, probably ruled from Cairo or Damascus, effectively would mean the end of independent Jordanian and Lebanese states (to the extent that Lebanese independence can be regarded as meaningful while Lebanon is still under virtual Syrian occupation). In multinational states, it may be possible to be a patriot and a nationalist simultaneously—provided one happens to be a member of the *Staatsvolk*. It is hardly feasible, however, for minorities. In Czechoslovakia, a Czech can, at one and the same time, support his state and his nation (or at least he could under Eduard Beneš and Alexander Dubček). However, an ethnic Magyar from southern Slovakia cannot simultaneously and without contradiction support